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1924, ‘*Sarfaroshi Ki Tamanna*’

It was in this maelstrom that the Hindustan Republican Association (HRA) was formed in an East Bengal village in 1924. Its goal was to organize armed resistance against British rule. One of its founding members was the poet Ram Prasad Bismil, who wrote the memorable revolutionary song ‘*sarfaroshi ki tamanna ab hamare dil meñ hai / dekhna hai zor kitna bazu-e-qatil meñ hai*’[1], (which translated means, ‘The desire for revolution is in our hearts / Let us see what strength there is in the arms of our executioner’[2]). This idea of the revolutionaries’ self-conception, in living out a vision of revolution, as found in their conversations, banter, and anecdotes, has been neatly captured in Dr Aparna Vaidik’s, *Waiting for Swaraj*[3], providing a valuable insight into their thinking. The other founding member was Sachindra Nath Sanyal, under whose influence Bhagat Singh was to come while a student at National College in Lahore in 1924 so as to become his protégé. Sanyal had penned the revolutionary tract *Bandi Jiwani*, which was to become the Bible of a new revolutionary politics. The clear objective of the HRA was the formation of a Federated Republic of the United States of India, which would be based on universal adult suffrage and which would have avoided the partition of India in 1947 had it come to fruition.

An armed struggle could not be waged without money. The recruitment and training of men, the procurement of arms and the organization of a nation-wide propaganda machine had to be financed. North Indian revolutionaries were the first to emerge as an organized group when in 1924 the Hindustan Republican Association (or Army) was formed by Ram Prasad Bismil, Sachindra Nath Sanyal, Sachindra Nath Bakshi and Jogesh